with Vietnam and Indonesia increased and financial and security cooperation with Singapore deepened, India's outreach to Southeast Asia proved difficult. In part, connectivity projects in Myanmar proved slow while trade negotiations marginalized Indian concerns. Ambivalence in some Southeast Asian countries about security cooperation, including in the South China Sea, impeded efforts. In time, efforts at engaging ASEAN as an institutional bloc gave way to more fruitful bilateral engagements with certain partners.

Experiments: The Economy and Institutions, 2014–2019

The Indian government under Modi attempted to reach out to some new constituencies between 2014 and 2019. Some of this represented an attempt to source investment and technology. For example, an agreement was brokered with Japan to finance and help establish India's first high speed rail line. On a visit to California, Modi also reached out to Silicon Valley, inviting major corporations to contribute to Indian digital infrastructure in various ways. New kinds of financial arrangements—whether tax agreements with Mauritius or a currency swap with Japan—were also finalized. However, perhaps the most transformative technological development in this period was indigenous: the continued adoption and development of India's biometric identification system, its links to mobile phones and bank accounts, and its employment for digital payments. [32] At the same time, the government expressed reluctance to enter into new trade agreements and none were concluded during Modi's first five-year term.

Internationally, India began reaching more to international blocs in various regions in an organized manner. In 2014 and 2016, India held summits with the leaders of Pacific Island countries. These fourteen countries had not previously received much attention in New Delhi, except for Fiji, which boasted a large Indian community. In 2015, India also hosted an Africa Summit, with over forty African leaders visiting India to bolster outreach to that continent. (The first such summit had been held in 2008, featuring fourteen African heads of state and government. A second